

“Shadow IT is forcing IT departments to become the IT service providers. So instead of the IT guys saying that they will take six months for a job, they are now saying that they can bring in a service provider from the outside world and can act as a broker of that service provider for the business guys.”

to five years ago, it was certainly a grey area. We have been doing our bit to demystify the cloud. It's not fear, per se. The cloud is IT-as-a-service, on demand. So when it comes to expectations from the cloud, you want it to run like any other site outside your IT scope. A CIO has to deliver to that expectation. So CIOs are building the infrastructure, which is giving users the experience that they want. There is no fear any more. Most progressive organisations are building or have built a cloud-like infrastructure, which is a combination of the private and public. The cloud has certainly brought about a new way of looking at IT.

Q In your survey, it was highlighted that the spending on IT is moving out of the hands of the IT department in an organisation. Please elaborate on this point.

If a business-oriented company approaches its IT department and asks it to fulfil a requirement, but is told that it will take six months to deliver what they want, the management will approach a service provider to deliver what it wants, within the time frame. The management would be happy to pay a service provider for doing the task. In this case, the decision to outsource is taken by the management and not the IT head. When the management takes such decisions, it is 'shadow IT'. So one is doing an IT job, but sans the IT department because it refused or couldn't meet the given requirements. So 31 per cent of the respondents of the survey believed that some of the IT budgets are no longer being controlled by IT heads, and that part of the budget was being spent by people like the chief marketing officer, the chief sales officer, etc.

Q Is shadow IT a threat to the traditional IT set-up or to IT heads?

Not really! What we are observing is that shadow IT is

also forcing the IT departments to become the IT service providers. So instead of the IT guys saying that they will take six months for a job, they are now saying that they can bring in a service provider from the outside world and can act as a broker of that service provider for the business guys. They can take the budget and get the job done. So it is not a threat. But, if they don't act as a broker, then it is a threat and the budgets will go away from them. The IT department has to now act as a broker of services or of service providers.

Q So, who is driving this trend of shadow IT?

The demand from businesses is the true driver in this case. IT is becoming a key lever for growth. Businesses need quicker responses now, because there is immense pressure from the customers. It is the customers and the changing business and customer needs that are driving this trend.

Q With this trend of SMAC coming in, do you think that the CIOs face a skills-gap challenge?

Yes, about 76 per cent of the CIOs surveyed by us do feel so. These trends of social, mobile, analytics and cloud have just started, and the skills the IT departments have are suited for today's needs. But they lack skills required for the times when these trends reach another level.

Q How does one bridge this gap?

There are two ways of doing this. One is the skills part, where companies work with colleges and students to train people. We have joined hands with more than 200 colleges in India, where we train students on the cloud and Big Data. We also have a training programme for our customers, during which they can send their people and get them trained on these latest technologies.

The second way is that instead of people-training, which of course is an important aspect, we emphasise the potential to bring in more software tools and automation, so that the resources use tools that are intelligent enough for the job. That's where the whole notion of a software defined set-up comes in. This should not be taken as replacing human resources with technology. It is, instead, augmenting their skills. It's like using a calculator. Do I know calculations... the answer is yes, but the calculator will help me speed up the calculations, and I should know how and when to use it. 

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